established itself for valid and even admirable reasons well before he became its best-known exponent.

Dera members are overwhelmingly Sikhs, though there are many Hindus among them. Sikhism is a faith that enjoins equality among its faithful, a message that had in the past inspired conversions of people from the lower Hindu castes, particularly Dalits and the 'Other Backward Classes'. But so deep is the prejudice in Indian society that many converted Sikhs found themselves treated no better by their co-religionists of higher castes, who dominate the official Sikh religious bodies which run the major gurudwaras or Sikh shrines.

Faced with an entrenched status quo, many Sikhs of less privileged backgrounds became disillusioned. Their feelings of anger and helplessness, compounded by poor education and soaring unemployment, led them to alcohol and drugs. Punjab became known as the drug capital of India, a reputation underscored in the searing portrayal of mass drug addiction in the recent hit film *Udta Punjab*.

It is in this context that the Dera Sacha Sauda and its charismatic leader emerged as saviours. For all his bling, Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh Insan exemplified an alternative life. The dera offers free education to its members and their children, free food for the hungry, and meaningful employment in its enterprises; it keeps the faithful off drugs, and more than jobs, it gives them a sense of meaning and purpose to their lives. In the process, it gives them that most precious and intangible of human needs—dignity and a sense of belonging.

Politicians played along with the Baba and his dera, and indeed with several other such religious movements; Dera Sacha Sauda is one of the biggest, but far from the only, of several deras dotting Punjab and Haryana. The deras, after all, helped keep social peace, tamp down discontent, and channel frustrations towards constructive activity. Rather than disapprove of them as dangerous cults, successive governments rushed to embrace them. Their religious nature offered a far safer alternative to drugs and crime. The deras ended addiction, replaced anomie with community and redirected despair to divinity, even if it came attired in flashy silver jackets and drove a Range Rover.